

an attempt at writing about this piece

draft

NOV 29, 2024

7:05 PM

Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky (1840-1893)

Violin Concerto in D Major, Op. 35 (1878)

II. Canzonetta

Tomoko Hida '26

Younger me would most certainly laugh at the way I play now. At music camp during one of the earlier years, Emma and I sat with our chests pressed against our knees, doing our best to contain our tiny convulsing by refusing to look up from our feet. We weren't discreet at all—the pews didn't quite hide our little folded 11 year old bodies. One of the violin faculty, Catherine, was performing a duet with her fiancé. He was so thoroughly involved in the music that playing the piece was not contingent on his arms, hands or fingers being in the right place, but for his mind to be in the right place. At the time, I thought he resembled a cartoon character caught in a sporadic and repetitive pre-sneeze sniffing, the kind that would make him progressively taller. He kept his eyes closed as he played, which I do now.

At 7:09pm I tuned my violin before 6 of my friends, 3 judges, and my violin teacher, Robyn. I took a bow after tuning, but I think I said "I forgot to bow earlier" as I bowed (no one clapped when I bowed because they already clapped as I walked on). I placed the first note with the kind of intention calligraphers wield as they set their first stroke, and embraced the music's gestures as my own. The longing, gasping, breathing in relief, thrashing around, grabbing and pulling with

the momentum of frustration, all tamed too soon in an apathetic resolve. What made my performance, or rather interpretation, was this narrative of emotion that I successfully embodied; the individual notes mattered much less. I felt proud of the intention with which I played regardless of the competition results. I received a congratulatory email later that same evening.

Thank you very much for your participation tonight. It is my pleasure to announce that you have been chosen as Winners of the 2024 Smith College Concerto Competition.

Thinking through my changing relationship with violin over the years is one way I can access some self-analysis, even for the times before I could write about my emotions let alone identify them as discrete. Within these stages of my violin career there exists, in any varying degree, (1) my appreciation for the instrument, (2) my instructor, and (3) what it meant for me socially.

— still writing —

ideas/stuff i was writing that i didnt include (yet?)

I spent the evening defending myself to my 17 year old night counselor

. One of the violin faculty was performing with her fiancé, a delicate violin duet that was most certainly beautiful and impressively unmemorable, well, because all I remember is that guy's damn face.

Faces the fiancé made:

- when cartoon characters get into a sporadic and repetitive sniffing that makes them progressively taller, arms stretched down beside them

- a sensitive grandfather prince (who is very stiff) begins to cry, but the 'begins to cry' period preceding the actual tears is the length of the duet